



BREAST SELF-EXAM GUIDE

A simple monthly check to know your breasts better.

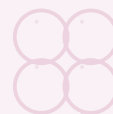
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INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- When to check, and how often
- The three-step routine: mirror, lying down, shower
- What is normal, and what needs a doctor



PLEASE READ

This guide is for awareness only. It does not replace medical advice, a clinical breast exam, or screening tests such as a mammogram.





1 Why breast self-exams matter

- Many breast changes are harmless, but some can be early signs of cancer.
- Regular self-exams help you learn what is normal **for you**, so you can spot changes earlier.
- Self-exams do not replace mammograms or clinical breast exams by a doctor. They are an extra way to stay aware.

If you notice any unusual change, talk to a doctor as soon as you can.

2 When to do a self-exam

- Do it **once a month**.
- **If you have periods:** choose the same time every month, ideally 3 to 5 days after your period ends, when breasts are less tender.
- **If you do not have periods** (after menopause or hysterectomy): choose a fixed date every month, for example the 1st or the 15th.

3 Step 1: Look in the mirror

Undress to the waist and stand in front of a mirror with good light.

1. Stand with your arms relaxed by your sides.
 - Look for changes in size, shape, or position of each breast.
 - Check whether the skin looks swollen, dimpled, or puckered.
2. Raise both arms above your head.
 - Look again for changes in the contour of the breasts or nipples.
3. Place your hands on your hips and press gently to tighten your chest muscles.
 - Look for any dimpling or pulling in of the skin or nipples.

If you see a new change that does not go away, note it down and speak to a doctor.



4 Step 2: Feel your breasts lying down

Lying down spreads the breast tissue more evenly, which makes it easier to feel. Lie on your back, place a small pillow or folded towel under your right shoulder, and put your right arm behind your head.

1. Use the pads of the 3 middle fingers of your left hand to examine your right breast.
2. Use small circular motions, about the size of a coin.
3. Use three levels of pressure:
 - **Light** to feel the tissue just under the skin
 - **Medium** to feel a bit deeper
 - **Firm** to feel near the rib cage and chest wall
4. Follow a set pattern so you cover the entire breast and armpit area, for example:
 - Vertical lines moving up and down
 - Or small circles moving outward from the nipple

Repeat the same steps on your left breast, using your right hand.

5 Step 3: Feel your breasts in the shower

Some people find it easier to feel changes when the skin is wet and slippery.

- Raise one arm behind your head.
- With the other hand, use the same circular motions and pressure levels as above.
- Cover the whole breast and the armpit area.

6 What is normal, what is not

Normal for many people

- Breasts that feel lumpy or uneven, especially before periods
- One breast slightly larger or shaped differently than the other

**Changes to get checked by a doctor**

- A new lump or thickening in the breast or underarm
- Any area that feels very different from the rest of the breast
- Skin dimpling or puckering
- Redness, scaling, or thickening of the nipple or breast skin
- A nipple turning inward or changing position
- Nipple discharge, especially if bloody or from one side only
- Swelling, warmth, or a sudden change in size or shape
- Persistent breast or nipple pain on one side

7 When to see a doctor

Contact a doctor or a breast clinic if:

- You find a new lump or an area that feels different.
- A change you noticed last month is still there.
- You have nipple discharge, especially with blood.
- You are simply worried about a change.

Do not panic. Most breast changes are not cancer, but it is always safer to check.

8 Important reminder

- A breast self-exam is a tool for awareness, not a formal screening test.
- You may still need mammograms and clinical breast exams as recommended for your age and risk.

Talk to your doctor about the screening plan that is right for you.



You know your body best.

Check once a month. Trust what you notice. Never feel silly for asking a doctor. Early awareness saves lives.

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Share this guide with someone you love.

Awareness only. This guide does not replace medical advice or screening tests.

